

A Two-Level Grammar of Nominal Potential

Lexical Structure, Syntactic Slots, and the Determiner Status of NOT

Monography

January 08, 2026

Author: MAKS PANNER

Affiliation: Independent Researcher in Linguistic Theory

Abstract

This monograph develops a two-level architecture for grammatical description in which (i) a lexical module computes category formation, phrase-internal selection, and headed structure, while (ii) a syntactic module computes sentence roles and the slot families that license constituents into those roles. The empirical focus is English NOT. Standard analyses assimilate not to clausal negation or to a dedicated functional head; however, not productively combines with diverse non-clausal materials (infinitivals, subordinate clauses used as arguments, PPs, APs, and participial phrases) whenever those materials function as nominal candidates in the syntactic role system. I formalize this generalization by defining nominal potential as a syntactic licensing property, and I split the traditional notion “NP” into NP_lex (noun-headed phrases computed by the lexical module) and NP_syn (any phrase with nominal potential in the syntactic module). NOT is then modeled as a syntactic determiner (Det_syn) that targets NP_syn and returns NP_syn. The analysis predicts the core distributional asymmetries (e.g., not the cat vs. *the not cat), allows limited recursion (not (not X)), avoids competition with lexical determiners, and yields a compact BNF grammar with an explicit lexical–syntactic interface. The framework also clarifies why uniform NP/DP implementations often overgenerate by positing silent nominal structure, and it provides a coherent perspective on diachronic changes in negation and nominalization as expansions of the NP_syn inventory and its operator system.

Keywords

two-level grammar; nominal potential; NP split; syntactic determiner; constituent negation; formal grammar; diachrony; interface; role licensing

Table of Contents

1. Preface and Scope
2. Introduction
3. Background: Categories, Functions, and Negation
4. The Lexical Module
5. The Syntactic Module: Roles and Slot Families
6. Diagnostics for Nominal Potential and the NP Split
7. NOT as a Syntactic Determiner (Det_syn)
8. Distribution, Constraints, and Markedness
9. Formal Grammar and the Lexical–Syntactic Interface (BNF)
10. Worked Derivations
11. Interpretation: Nominal Potential as Type Access
12. The Semantics of NP_syn-level NOT
13. Cross-Linguistic Calibration
14. Why Uniform NP/DP Implementations Overgenerate
15. Diachrony: Negation and Nominalization
16. Computational and Psycholinguistic Implications
17. Conclusion and Future Work
- Appendix A. Notation
- Appendix B. Master BNF Specification
- Appendix C. Extended Derivations
- References

1. Preface and Scope

This book is a methodological argument with an empirical anchor. The methodological claim is that grammatical theory benefits from a disciplined separation between two kinds of description that are routinely conflated: category and function. Category is computed in a lexical module: it determines what a head is, what it selects, and how phrase-internal structure is assembled.

Function is computed in a syntactic module: it determines which constituents occupy subject, predicate, and object roles (and their discourse refinements), and it provides the slot families that license constituents into those roles.

The empirical anchor is the English item NOT. Its distribution is unusually revealing because it combines not only with canonical noun phrases (not a cat) but also with infinitivals (not to swim), subordinate clauses used as arguments (not that he left), PPs in contrastive/topic positions (not in the house), APs (not ready), and participial phrases (not sitting in silence). These complements share neither a head category nor a uniform internal morphology. What they share is that they can be hosted as nominal candidates—units that a clause can place into subject/object/topic slots and treat as discourse objects.

Cross-linguistic remarks are used as calibration and as a source of predictions, not as exhaustive typology. Throughout, descriptive claims (what the system must represent to capture the data) are separated from implementation choices (how a particular formalism encodes those claims).

2. Introduction

2.1 Category conflation and the NP problem

Many frameworks use “NP” ambiguously: sometimes as a noun-headed phrase (a lexical category), and sometimes as “whatever fills the subject/object position” (a syntactic function). This ambiguity becomes visible the moment we observe that noun-headed phrases can occur as predicates (He is a doctor), and that non-noun constituents can occupy subject slots (To leave now would be a mistake).

If NP is treated as a single object, nominalization looks like a mysterious operation that turns “non-nominals” into “nominals.” This pushes analyses toward silent structure: covert N heads, covert D heads, or nominalizing projections inserted whenever a clause-like or phrase-like constituent behaves as an argument. The present approach avoids both the mystery and the covert proliferation by treating nominal behavior as a property of syntactic hosting rather than lexical headedness.

2.2 The empirical trigger: NOT

English not is commonly introduced as a clausal negator. Yet its constituent uses are broad. Consider the following patterns, where the bracketed constituents are not homogeneous in lexical category:

- (1) a. not [a cat]
b. not [to swim]
c. not [that he left]
d. not [in the house]
e. not [ready]
f. not [sitting in silence]

The goal is to state a single generalization that covers (1a–f) without multiplying homophonous nots, and without forcing covert nominal structure.

2.3 Contributions

The principal contributions are: (i) a two-level architecture separating lexical selection from syntactic role licensing; (ii) a definition of nominal potential as a syntactic property independent of noun-headedness; (iii) a formal split between NP_lex (noun-headed phrases) and NP_syn (nominal-slot candidates); (iv) a determiner-level analysis of NOT as Det_syn, capturing its distribution and its non-competition with articles; and (v) a compact formal grammar (BNF) plus derivations and an interpretation component sufficient to state scope, recursion, and selection facts with explicit interface principles.

3. Background: Categories, Functions, and Negation

3.1 Lexical categories and selectional profiles

Lexical categories (N, V, A, P, etc.) are defined by distribution, morphology, and selection. Heads select complements as part of a valency profile (Baker 2003). Selection is phrase-internal; it does not presuppose sentence roles. A verb may select an NP_lex, a PP_lex, or a clausal complement; whether that complement ultimately appears as an object, a subject, or a topic is a matter of syntactic hosting.

3.2 Syntactic functions and role schemas

Subject, predicate, and object are syntactic functions (roles). Languages encode these roles via word order, agreement, case, and information-structural marking. Methodologically, functional labels should not be used as if they were lexical categories. Treating “whatever is in subject position” as an NP is harmless only if NP is explicitly a functional class—precisely the role played here by NP_syn.

3.3 The NP/DP tradition and its limits

The DP hypothesis treats articles as heads of a functional projection DP that takes NP as complement (Abney 1987). This is useful for describing article syntax in noun-headed phrases. However, DP theory does not by itself solve the nominalization problem: it does not explain why non-noun constituents behave nominally in subject/object positions. Implementations often respond by adding silent nominal structure (covert D, covert N, nominalizing heads). The risk is descriptive non-falsifiability: if any constituent can be made a DP by hypothesis, the analysis ceases to predict where nominal behavior should occur.

3.4 Negation families

Negation is often divided into clausal negation, constituent negation, and polarity licensing (Horn 1989; Haegeman 1995; Zeijlstra 2004). English not participates in all three. The present monograph isolates a constituent use of not that targets nominal candidates and shows that this use provides a diagnostic for nominal potential as a licensing condition separate from clausehood.

4. The Lexical Module

4.1 Inventory and phrase-internal structure

The lexical module supplies (i) a set of lexical categories, (ii) head-driven phrase structure rules, and (iii) selectional constraints. A minimal inventory sufficient for the present purpose is N, V, A, P, and Det_lex.

4.2 NP_lex: noun-headed phrases

Definition 1 (NP_lex). NP_lex is a phrase headed by N. Articles and possessives are Det_lex elements that combine with nouns in the lexical module. NP_lex may contain adjectival modifiers and PP modifiers, subject to standard constraints.

```
Lexical schemata (informal):  
NP_lex  -> (Det_lex) N (Mod_lex) *  
Mod_lex -> AP_lex | PP_lex  
PP_lex  -> P NP_lex  
AP_lex  -> A (PP_lex) ?
```

4.3 Lexical complements and internal argument structure

Complementhood is a lexical notion: a complement is selected by a head as part of its valency profile. This matters because it prevents a common slide: treating “object” as if it were “complement.” A verb can select a clause complement; that clause may later function as an object, a subject, or a topic in syntax. The lexical module cannot decide that; it only constrains selection possibilities.

4.4 Why NOT is not lexical

NOT does not behave like Det_lex. It is not restricted to nouns; it does not occupy the article slot inside NP_lex; it does not participate in determiner systems as a member of the article paradigm; and it can attach to non-noun complements. Treating NOT as lexical therefore forces either multiple homophonous NOTs or extensive covert structure. A syntactic-operator analysis avoids both.

5. The Syntactic Module: Roles and Slot Families

5.1 Role primitives

The syntactic module is defined by sentence roles. For present purposes, the core schema is Subject–Predicate–Object (SPO), where Predicate is the predication center and Subject/Object are argumental slots licensed by it. Refinements (topic, focus, oblique roles) are treated as structured sub-slots or alternative hosting sites, but remain governed by the same licensing logic.

5.2 Slot families and admissible hosts

Each role induces a family of slots. The crucial claim is that slot families are typed by function, not by lexical category. Nominal slots do not require noun headedness; they require nominal potential. This is why infinitivals, clauses, PPs, APs, and participial phrases can occupy nominal slots in English under appropriate constructions.

5.3 Nominal potential

Definition 2 (Nominal potential). A phrase has nominal potential iff it is licensed to occupy a nominal slot in the syntactic module (subject, object, or a discourse-nominal position such as topic). Nominal potential is a property of interface licensing. It can be diagnosed by (i) distribution in nominal slots, (ii) compatibility with nominal proforms and anaphora in relevant constructions, and (iii) compatibility with NP_{syn}-level operators such as constituent not.

5.4 NP_{syn}: the functional nominal class

Definition 3 (NP_{syn}). NP_{syn} is the class of phrases with nominal potential. NP_{syn} is not a single lexical category; it is a family of admissible host types. NP_{lex} is included as one member, but NP_{syn} also includes infinitivals, certain clauses, PPs, APs, and participial phrases when used argumentally or topically.

6. Diagnostics for Nominal Potential and the NP Split

6.1 Hosting diagnostics

The most direct test for nominal potential is hosting: can the phrase occupy a subject slot, object slot, or topic slot without overt nominal morphology?

- | | |
|--|---------------------------|
| (2) a. [To swim] is fun. | (Infinitival subject) |
| b. I regret [to leave so early]. | (Infinitival complement; |
| register-sensitive) | |
| c. I remember [that he left]. | (Clausal complement) |
| d. [In the garden] is where I found it. | (PP in focus/topic frame) |
| e. [Ready] is how he seemed. | (AP in nominal slot via |
| wh-cleft) | |
| f. [Sitting in silence] was the problem. | (Participial/eventive |
| nominal) | |

Where these configurations are grammatical, the bracketed phrases qualify as NP_syn in those uses. The theory does not require that all such uses be equally unmarked; it requires only that their availability be structurally accountable in terms of role licensing.

6.2 Operator diagnostics

A second diagnostic is the availability of NP_syn-level operators: operators that do not care about noun-headedness but care about nominal hosting. Constituent not is precisely such an operator. If not can precede a phrase and the result can occupy a nominal slot, that phrase is a strong candidate for NP_syn membership.

6.3 Identity and re-identifiability

Because nominal potential is a licensing property, it must be trackable under discourse operations (topicalization, coordination, ellipsis). NP_syn is therefore treated as a re-identifiable host class: once a phrase is admitted as NP_syn in a derivation, it remains eligible for nominal tracking. This is a precondition for treating NP_syn-level operators as genuine syntactic objects rather than ad hoc modifiers.

6.4 The NP split

The split is thus: NP_lex is defined by headedness and computed in the lexical module; NP_syn is defined by hosting eligibility and computed in the syntactic module. This is a principled way to preserve the descriptive utility of noun-phrase structure while accounting for the systematic nominal behavior of non-noun constituents.

7. NOT as a Syntactic Determiner (Det_syn)

7.1 The core rule

The central generalization can be stated as a single licensing rule in the syntactic module:

```
Det_syn ::= NOT
NP_syn  -> Det_syn NP_syn
        i.e., NP_syn -> NOT NP_syn
```

NOT selects NP_syn (nominal potential), not NP_lex (noun headedness). The output is again NP_syn, so the resulting constituent is hostable wherever NP_syn is hostable.

7.2 Non-competition with articles

Because NOT is Det_syn rather than Det_lex, it does not compete with a/the/my. This predicts the basic asymmetry:

- (3) a. not [a cat]
- b. *a [not cat]
- c. not [the cat]
- d. *the [not cat]

7.3 Why NOT is determiner-like

Determiners are operators that package a nominal candidate for hosting and quantificational/selectional behavior. NOT, in the constituent use at issue, packages a nominal candidate as excluded relative to a discourse contrast set. It is therefore determiner-like at the syntactic level: it changes the admissibility profile of the nominal candidate without changing its internal lexical headedness.

8. Distribution, Constraints, and Markedness

8.1 Distribution over NP_syn members

NOT combines with NP_lex and with non-noun NP_syn members in the constructions that license them as nominal candidates.

- (4) a. not [a cat] / not [my neighbor]
b. not [to swim]
c. not [that he left] / not [because he was tired]
d. not [in the house] / not [on Tuesday]
e. not [ready] / not [happy]
f. not [sitting in silence]

8.2 Constraint: NOT is external to NP_lex

The theory predicts that NOT cannot appear inside NP_lex as a lexical determiner competitor. This follows if NP_lex is computed by the lexical module with a determiner system Det_lex that does not contain NOT. NP_syn-level NOT can take NP_lex as its complement, yielding not [Det_lex N], but the reverse configuration is excluded.

8.3 Construction sensitivity and pragmatic markedness

The analysis does not predict that every NP_syn member will be equally natural under NOT in every discourse condition. Many uses are constrained by information structure, processing load, and register. The claim is weaker and testable: when a phrase type is licensed as a nominal candidate, the NOT operator is available in principle; when a phrase type is not licensed as a nominal candidate, NOT is blocked.

8.4 Iteration and recursion

NP_syn recursion permits nested NOT in principle (not (not X)). This is predicted structurally because NP_syn → NOT NP_syn is itself recursive. Iteration is often pragmatically marked, but the structural availability of iteration is a non-trivial argument for treating NOT as an NP_syn-level operator rather than exclusively as a clausal head.

9. Formal Grammar and the Lexical–Syntactic Interface (BNF)

9.1 Lexical grammar

Lexical categories:

N, V, A, P, Det_lex

Det_lex ::= a | the | this | that | these | those | my | your | his | her
| its | our | their | Ø

NP_lex ::= (Det_lex) N (Mod_lex)*

Mod_lex ::= AP_lex | PP_lex

PP_lex ::= P NP_lex

AP_lex ::= A (PP_lex)?

VP_lex ::= V (NP_lex)? (PP_lex)* (Clause_lex)?

9.2 Syntactic grammar

Role schema:

S ::= Subject Predicate (Object)

Subject ::= NP_syn

Object ::= NP_syn

Predicate ::= VP_syn

Det_syn ::= NOT

NP_syn ::= NP_lex
| InfP_syn
| Clause_syn
| PP_lex
| AP_lex
| PartP_syn
| Det_syn NP_syn

InfP_syn ::= to V (NP_syn)? (PP_lex)*

PartP_syn ::= V-ing (NP_syn)? (PP_lex)*

Clause_syn ::= that S | because S | when S | if S

VP_syn ::= V
| V NP_syn
| V PP_lex
| V NP_syn PP_lex
| V Clause_syn

9.3 Interface principles

The interface imports lexical phrases into syntactic hosting positions. NP_lex is always admissible as NP_syn. Other lexical phrases become NP_syn only when a syntactic construction licenses them as nominal candidates (e.g., clefts, topicalization frames, raising/copular environments). NOT is defined only in the syntactic module, ensuring its distribution is sensitive to role licensing rather than lexical selection.

10. Worked Derivations

10.1 To swim is fun

Subject -> NP_syn -> InfP_syn -> to swim
Predicate -> VP_syn -> is fun

10.2 Not to swim is dangerous

Subject -> NP_syn -> NOT NP_syn -> NOT InfP_syn -> not to swim
Predicate -> VP_syn -> is dangerous

10.3 Not that he left bothered me

Subject -> NP_syn -> NOT Clause_syn -> not that S
Predicate -> VP_syn -> bothered NP_syn
Object -> NP_syn -> me

10.4 Not in the house is where I found it

Topic/Subject -> NP_syn -> NOT PP_lex -> not in the house
Predicate -> is where I found it

10.5 Recursion

NP_syn recursion permits nested NOT (not (not X)). Semantic stabilization is pragmatic; structural availability is grammatical.

NP_syn -> NOT NP_syn -> NOT (NOT NP_syn) -> not (not X)

11. Interpretation: Nominal Potential as Type Access

11.1 Generalized argument type

Nominal potential can be modeled as access to a generalized argument type e^* —an argumental domain that can host individuals, events, propositions, locations, properties, and other discourse-manageable objects. Under this approach, NP_syn denotes elements of e^* ; NP_lex denotes individuals (or generalized quantifiers, depending on the semantic architecture). Non-noun NP_syn members are coerced into e^* when hosted in nominal slots, consistent with standard type-shifting ideas but anchored here in syntactic licensing.

11.2 Nominalization as licensing, not covert N

On this view, nominalization is not primarily a derivational operation that inserts a covert noun head. It is a set of licensing strategies that make a non-noun constituent eligible for e^* hosting. English uses multiple such strategies (infinitivals, gerunds, complementizers, clefts, and copular/raising frames). These expand the NP_syn inventory while keeping lexical headedness explicit.

12. The Semantics of NP_syn-level NOT

12.1 NOT as exclusion over e*

In constituent use, NOT can be modeled as an exclusion operator over e*: it maps a candidate x in e* to an excluded variant relative to a contextually supplied contrast set. When x is an individual, the effect is individual-exclusion; when x is an event or proposition, the effect is event/proposition-exclusion. This explains why the same operator can attach to diverse complements without requiring homophony.

12.2 Scope

Because NOT is inside NP_syn, its scope is the nominal candidate itself. This distinguishes NP_syn-level NOT from clausal negation, which targets propositional content in the clausal spine. English expresses both. NP_syn-level NOT is typically associated with contrastive focus and corrective constructions (not X, but Y).

12.3 Iteration

Iteration (not (not X)) is predicted but pragmatically marked. The model derives iteration without additional projections: recursion is simply NP_syn recursion. This keeps the grammar compact and makes iteration an empirical question rather than a structural accident.

13. Cross-Linguistic Calibration

The present monograph is primarily English-based, but the architecture makes typological predictions. If nominal potential is a licensing property of syntactic role systems, then languages with robust nominalization strategies should show a larger inventory of NP_syn members (clause-like and predicate-like materials that are freely hostable as arguments). Conversely, languages that restrict clause-like materials from argument positions should display tighter NP_syn inventories and, correlatively, tighter distributions of NP_syn-level operators.

13.1 External negation and constituent operators

Many languages exhibit “external” or constituent negation strategies that target non-finite material, topics, or contrastive constituents. A hypothesis consistent with the two-level view is that such strategies are best modeled as operators over nominal candidates (NP_syn-like classes), rather than as uniform clausal heads. The hypothesis is falsifiable: it predicts a strong correlation between the availability of argumental non-finites/nominalized clauses and the availability of negation operators that attach to those units.

13.2 Calibration targets

Initial calibration targets include languages with overt clause nominalizers (e.g., Japanese koto/no, Korean kes, various Indo-European infinitival/gerundive systems) and languages with rich constituent-negation morphology. Detailed typology is deferred to future work, but the

architecture provides a clear testing program: determine NP_syn membership via hosting diagnostics, then test whether negation/focus operators pattern with that membership.

14. Why Uniform NP/DP Implementations Overgenerate

14.1 NP is lexical, not syntactic

If NP is defined lexically as “noun-headed phrase,” it cannot simultaneously be the syntactic class of all nominal hosts. Treating NP as both forces ad hoc decisions about whether an infinitival or clause is “really” an NP. The NP split avoids the dilemma by assigning lexical headedness to NP_lex and syntactic hosting to NP_syn.

14.2 DP does not predict NOT

DP theory predicts that determiners select NP_lex. If NOT were a determiner head in the DP system, it would be expected to select NP_lex. But constituent not selects complements that are not NP_lex. To reconcile this, DP implementations often posit covert NP_lex complements (silent nouns) or reclassify non-noun constituents as covert NPs. Both moves reduce empirical content by making nominal potential a byproduct of silent structure.

14.3 Overgeneration risks

Once silent nominal structure is freely available, almost any constituent can be forced into DP. The analysis then predicts weak constraints on determiner-like operator distribution and makes it difficult to state why certain constituency patterns are unavailable. The NP_syn analysis retains explicit limits: only constituents licensed for nominal hosting are eligible for NP_syn-level NOT, and licensing is empirically testable.

15. Diachrony: Negation and Nominalization

15.1 Negation cycles

Negation often cycles through reinforcement and reanalysis (Jespersen 1917; Horn 1989; Dahl 2010). The present framework highlights a specific diachronic hypothesis: constituent-negation uses arise naturally in focus and contrast structures, where operators target constituents that are independently hostable as nominal candidates. Once such uses are conventionalized, the operator becomes sensitive to nominal potential rather than clausehood, and its grammar can be captured by an NP_syn-level rule.

15.2 Nominalization as expansion of NP_syn

Nominalization strategies—dedicated nominalizers, case systems, complementizer systems, gerundive morphology, and conversion—can be unified as expansions of NP_syn: they increase the number of constituents that can be licensed as nominal candidates. This predicts a coupling

between the growth of nominalization devices and the availability of NP_syn-level operator systems (including negative and focus operators).

16. Computational and Psycholinguistic Implications

16.1 Parsing architecture

A two-level architecture suggests a natural division of labor for parsers: (i) a lexical component that builds head-driven local structures with selectional constraints, and (ii) a role-licensing component that assigns constituents to subject/predicate/object slots and computes nominal-potential coercions. In computational terms, NP_syn is not a tag but a licensing outcome: a phrase may be retyped as NP_syn given constructional evidence.

16.2 Predicting attachment and scope

Treating constituent not as Det_syn predicts that its attachment decisions depend on nominal hosting and information structure rather than on the clausal spine alone. This offers an implementable heuristic: prefer NOT attachment to the smallest constituent that is independently hostable as NP_syn in the local construction. Such heuristics can be evaluated against corpora and compared to clausal NegP-only baselines.

16.3 Processing

The model predicts increased processing cost for NP_syn uses that require stronger coercion (e.g., AP/PP in subject position), and it predicts that not will be more acceptable with those materials in discourse contexts that explicitly establish a contrast set. These predictions can be tested using acceptability judgments and self-paced reading paradigms.

17. Conclusion and Future Work

The two-level architecture and the NP split jointly yield a compact explanation for the broad constituent distribution of English not: not is a syntactic determiner over NP_syn, not a lexical determiner over NP_lex and not exclusively a clausal head. The rule NP_syn -> NOT NP_syn captures the observed complement diversity, allows limited recursion, and prevents competition with articles. The analysis also clarifies why uniform NP/DP approaches frequently require silent structure that blurs falsifiable predictions.

Limitations. This monograph isolates NP_syn-level not and does not attempt a full account of polarity items, auxiliary negation, or negative concord. It also treats the role schema at a high level and leaves finer-grained information-structural slots (topic/focus) to future refinement.

Future work should (i) operationalize nominal potential diagnostics in corpus studies, (ii) test whether NOT-like operators in other languages align with NP_syn membership, and (iii) explore

computational implementations of the two-level interface in parsers that explicitly separate lexical selection from role licensing.

Appendix A. Notation

NP_lex : noun-headed phrase (lexical module)
NP_syn : phrase with nominal potential (syntactic module)
Det_lex : lexical determiners (articles, possessives)
Det_syn : syntactic determiners (operators over NP_syn), with NOT as the central case
e* : generalized argument type associated with nominal potential

Appendix B. Master BNF Specification

For convenience, the master grammar is reproduced here as a single block.

```
S ::= Subject Predicate (Object)
Subject ::= NP_syn
Object ::= NP_syn
Predicate ::= VP_syn

Det_syn ::= NOT

NP_syn ::= NP_lex
        | InfP_syn
        | Clause_syn
        | PP_lex
        | AP_lex
        | PartP_syn
        | Det_syn NP_syn

NP_lex ::= (Det_lex) N (Mod_lex)*
Det_lex ::= a | the | this | that | these | those | my | your | his | her
          | its | our | their | Ø
Mod_lex ::= AP_lex | PP_lex
PP_lex ::= P NP_lex
AP_lex ::= A (PP_lex)?

InfP_syn ::= to V (NP_syn)? (PP_lex)*
PartP_syn ::= V-ing (NP_syn)? (PP_lex)*
Clause_syn ::= that S | because S | when S | if S

VP_syn ::= V
        | V NP_syn
        | V PP_lex
        | V NP_syn PP_lex
        | V Clause_syn
```

Appendix C. Extended Derivations

C.1 Nested NOT

NP_syn -> NOT NP_syn -> NOT (NOT NP_syn) -> not (not X)
Interpretation is compositionally available; pragmatic felicity depends on contrast-set accommodation.

C.2 Clause + infinitive hybrid

not [that he tried [to swim]]

Clause_syn hosts an embedded infinitival; NOT applies to the clausal nominal as NP_syn.

References

- Abney, Steven. 1987. The English noun phrase in its sentential aspect. PhD dissertation, MIT.
- Baker, Mark. 2003. Lexical categories: Verbs, nouns, and adjectives. Cambridge University Press.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1970. Remarks on nominalization. In R. Jacobs & P. Rosenbaum (eds.), *Readings in English transformational grammar*, 184–221. Ginn.
- Croft, William. 2001. *Radical Construction Grammar: Syntactic theory in typological perspective*. Oxford University Press.
- Dahl, Östen. 2010. Typology of negation. In L. Horn (ed.), *The expression of negation*, 9–38. De Gruyter.
- Haegeman, Liliane. 1995. *The syntax of negation*. Cambridge University Press.
- Horn, Laurence. 1989. *A natural history of negation*. University of Chicago Press.
- Jespersen, Otto. 1917. *Negation in English and other languages*. København: A. F. Høst.
- Zeijlstra, Hedde. 2004. *Sentential negation and negative concord*. PhD dissertation, University of Amsterdam.